
UNIT 3 REPORT WRITING

Structure

- 3.1 Introduction
- 3.2 Objectives
- 3.3 Meaning of Report
 - 3.3.1 Objectives of Report writing
 - 3.3.2 Importance of Report writing
 - 3.3.3 Report writing guidelines
 - 3.3.4 Benefits of Report writing
- 3.4 Types of Reports
- 3.5 Essentials for preparation of Report writing
- 3.6 Drafting the Technical Report
- 3.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 3.8 Answers to Check Your Progress
- 3.9 Terminal Questions
- 3.10 Suggested Readings
- 3.11 Activities

3.1 INTRODUCTION

In modern office, executives have to take various decisions which are based on logical thinking. Logical thinking can be derived through factual and sound data. Management is not based on intuition but on scientific methods which are derived from facts and figures. It is continuously supplying all kinds of information to the executives through reports of different kinds. Such information is required to be communicated in a written form to save time as well as to provide record. Therefore, Reports- as the source of communication has become the primary task of modern office today.

The main purpose of a report is to provide information to the executive so that they may take timely decisions and actions accordingly. The report may vary in length to meet the outcome. Short reports may be produced in the form of memo format but longer reports will need to follow definite structure.

3.2 OBJECTIVES

After studying this unit learner will be able to:-

- Define meaning of report.
- State the important of report.
- Explain the type of report.

- Explain the essential for drafting report.
- Meaning of technical report and its drafting.

3.3 MEANING OF REPORT

Report is a summary of information. It is a communication from someone who has information to someone who wants to use that information. A report is a form of narrative or statement which presents facts relating to an event or state of business affairs which are necessary for an evaluation of progress and for decisions. It is a presentation of facts and findings about an activity. It is objective, impartial presentation of facts. It may arise out of available factual data or through enquiry, investigation, survey, interview, experiment etc. A mere expression of opinion without supporting factual data is not a report.

Office reports may be regarded as the vehicles of communicating information to those who need that information and will use it. They also provide valuable records. They serve as usual means of developing public relation and goodwill.

George R. Terry defined report as “A written statement on collection of facts, events, and opinions and usually express as summarized and interpretative value of this information. It may deal with past accomplishments, present conditions, or probable future developments.”

According to **Johnson** “A good report is a communication that contains factual information organized and presented in clear, correct and coherent language.” Reports are used by members of management to plan, organize and control business operations. Each manager in an organization has to report to his senior for which he has accepted the responsibility.

3.3.1 Objectives of Report Writing

Office report has the following objectives: –

- Objective of office reports is to communicate the information to those who need it.
- To facilitate planning and co-ordination by presenting factual information.
- To provide the information to shareholders, creditors, investors, customers and also general public.
- To facilitate the management to take appropriate course of action.
- To provide valuable records of documents to the office which can be used as future reference?
- To provide facts and results of an enquiry.
- To give the basis of measuring the performance of executives.

The above mentioned objectives of report writing can only be achieved if the report is written in a simple language, is brief and comprehensive and also if it is supported by reliable data and factual information.

3.3.2 Importance of Report Writing

Report writing is very challenging, interesting and fun loving. It is not something separate from real work. It is necessary and integral part of work. It is quite valuable and useful because:—

- It helps to keep records.
- It is the source of information.
- It tells about future success and failures.
- It keeps on knowing what we are doing.
- It encourages the donors as it keeps them informed what happened to their donations.
- It helps other people know about the development of their project.
- Other people are encouraged to do their own project.
- Helps researchers to do their work.
- Helps to determine further actions.
- It is also important for evaluation purpose.
- Helpful to the govt. to know their performance to bring different changes in policies, programs etc.

Check Your Progress I

Fill in the blanks:

- a) Bad reports are generally not _____.
- b) _____ should be given on major points.
- c) Brief report means _____.
- d) Reports are the _____.
- e) Report writing talks about failures and _____.
- f) Always write the report in _____ voice.
- g) Reports clarify the relationship between input and _____.
- h) Reports provide information for making _____.

3.3.3 Report Writing (Tips and Guidelines)

Report writing is an art. It is that skill which can be studied and cultivated. It is an essential means of communication in the form of recommendation or information which is placed before the management for taking different decisions. A report which does not stimulate thought has no useful purpose. It does not justify the cost and efforts incurred on its preparation. It is necessary for maintaining transparency.

The tips and guidelines about report - writing are valuable to employees at all levels. These are as under:—

- Avoid the use of passive voice.
- Prepare the report after knowing your audience and need of readers.
- Write the report concisely (briefly) but comprehensively.
- Write in simple language.
- It should be well planned and well organized.
- It should follow the logical conclusion.
- It may also give recommendation.

After following all above mentioned tips, report should be prepared after doing the needful work:

1. Collection of relevant facts and figures.
2. The arrangement of data in logical manner.
3. Arriving at conclusion.

Thus a good report is extremely valuable. If the above mentioned tips are followed, report writing skills can be improved and personnel's can also be trained accordingly.

3.3.4 Benefits of Report Writing

- It arranges and organizes the available information.
- It identifies any missing information.
- It makes the author to get more total and neutral view.
- It makes analysis and assessment easier.
- It classifies the relationship between activities and results. (Input and output).
- It assists the author to make a less biased self assessment.
- It provides the information for making recommendation.

- It can lead to changes in objectives, strategies and activities in future office.
- It gives proper feedback to bring any changes in future activities.

3.4 TYPES OF REPORTS

Reports can be classified as under for the purpose of **office usage**.

- 1) **Routine Reports** – It contains the statement of facts in a detailed manner without any recommendations. It conveys the information to the management on the progress of some matter. These are prepared at regular intervals and are based on present facts and figures. These may be a production reports, sales reports, cost report, director's report etc.
- 2) **Special Report** – It is presented to the superior who has been entrusted with the responsibility of preparation. It usually contains the advice or recommendation of the reporter on non- routine matters. It may include research report, turnover report, plant location report etc.
- 3) **Statutory report** – The report which are necessary to the prepared as per the requirement of law. For example, under Company's act of 2013, a Joint Stock Company should prepare and file the following reports with the registrar of companies.
 - Directors report to the Annual General Meeting.
 - Annual returns.
 - Statutory report at the statutory meeting of the company
 - An auditor's report.
 - Reports by Inspectors appointed to investigate the affairs of the company.
- 4) **Technical report** – Technical reports are prepared by technocrats and their contents are generally in the form of figures and statistics. It may be engineering report, plant maintenance report, project report etc.

Reports may also be classified as: – **Formal or Informal**

- 1) **Formal report**- It consist of several fairly standardized parts. It is presented to the reader in a rather formal format. These reports are generally analytical in nature. These reports are either statutory reports or non- statutory reports. Reports submitted by officials or executives of companies, societies, local bodies etc. are usually formal reports.
- 2) **Informal reports** – This report does not follow any prescribed or official form or procedure. It may involve verbal reporting in person or over the telephone. It is like the informal, communication.

These reports may be of following types –

Short- report brief discussion of facts.

Progress report providing information about the progress of specific plan.

Staff report presenting facts and giving recommendation on staff matters.

Justification report justifying a particular course of action.

Check Your Progress II

Fill in the blanks:

- a) Reports prepared as per the requirement of law are called _____ reports.
- b) Director's report to the annual general meeting is called _____.
- c) Technical reports are prepared by _____.
- d) A formal report is typically _____ in nature.
- e) The report which does not contain any opinion or recommendation is called _____ report.
- f) The reports which do not follow any official procedure are called _____ reports.

3.5 ESSENTIALS FOR PREPARATION OF REPORT WRITING

Reports are necessary to communicate progress, indicate achievements and make relevant recommendations. They are useful for evaluation purpose and may assist in making the necessary adjustments on an ongoing project. Report writing is actually a challenging and exciting activity. Therefore, a formal report generally has the following essentials:

1) Preparation

Preparation of report involves many activities. It includes selecting an attractive report title, determining topics to be covered and listing points of the topics. Under preparation, writer has to acknowledge all those who offered assistance during the process. The acknowledgement should be as sincere as possible. After acknowledgment, writer creates a summary abstract, which communicates the scope of reports. An executive summary closely follows the summary abstract showing the purpose of the report background of the report and source of information.

2) Introduction

This stage communicates the main objectives of the reports. It covers a wide area including the background information, literature review, scope of study and research methodology used. The introduction phase should be very short and concise. It should, however, set the stage for a clearer and logical flow of report. A writer should understand the main objectives of the report before embarking on writing it in the first place. This will assist in ensuring that you do not go out of topic or experience writer's block, a situation where a writer suddenly runs out of ideas.

3) Writing the body

The body is one of the most important parts of report since it holds all facts and relevant information, as regards of the problem. All information should be made available in a straight forward way without beating the bush. Although it is a report, it is advisable to use active voice as compared to the passive voice, since the former is clearer, more direct and has a natural role.

It is wise to use heading when writing the body since doing this maintains the logical flow of the report and it is much easier for the readers to follow and understand. The titles and subtitles may be bolded and text may be formatted to ensure clear information. The transition from one stage to another should be smooth, ensuring that the reader does not get lost.

4) Conclusion

This indicates the end of the report. It should be the summary of the whole report covering all aspects of the document and any underlying themes. Before writing the conclusion, it is advisable to make a draft first of the whole document and then note the main points to sum up. There should not be any inclusion of new information in the conclusion.

The conclusion of report also involves listing the recommendations of the research. After studying the whole report and under standing the underlying problem, one is able to make recommendations on the possible solutions.

Some reports also include list of references. A list of references shows the main sources of information for the writer. The list facilitates easier verification of the information. Just in case you might need to edit the report, it would be easier to find the information you are looking for if you follow the list of references.

Thus on the basis of above mentioned criteria, the report will not be only valuable to you, advisors, peers, juniors down the line but will also be readable and useful for the technical community in general.

Check Your Progress III

Fill in the blanks:

- a) Give a _____ to the report.
- b) Keep the report brief but _____.
- c) Make only those reports which have _____ aims.
- d) A mere expression of opinion without supporting factual data is not a _____.
- e) Report should always be written in _____ when written by an individual.

Rules for Report-writing

The following are the guiding rules for drafting reports:

- Make reports which has only definite aims. What is expected from it?
- Write always in first person be positive and use positive statements.
- Write in narrative form, stating the facts, finding and recommendations in a logical manner.
- Keep to the subject- facts not related to the subject should be strictly excluded.
- Strive for simplicity- use simple words and sentences.
- Carefully observe the rules of punctuation- otherwise sense of report will be lost.
- Separate facts from opinions.-A mere expression of opinion without supporting factual data is not a report.
- Give a title to the report -so that at glance it can be noticed what the report is about?
- The report should be introduced by quoting the terms of reference-it should be made clear why the report is required and what it contains.
- Make specific recommendations.
- Give the correct and complete data or factual information.
- Keep report brief, but complete and comprehensive.
- Always read everything you have written – So do not regard it as finished until you are satisfied that it expresses exactly what you wanted to convey.

Specimen of report writing

General report to the Principal regarding difficulties experienced in the operation of the time –table during the ensuing semester.

The Principal,
XYZ
Delhi.

Dear Sir,

As I have been given the charge of smooth operation of the time-table but in the course of performing my duties, I have noticed certain difficulties in smooth operation of the time-table which I now beg to submit before you:

Lack of Punctuality

I have noticed that punctuality in attendance is not maintained by the members of the staff in general. Due to which they become late in taking their class. In my view defective system of recording staff attendance is mainly responsible for the lack of punctuality.

Ineptitude of certain teachers

The smooth operation of time- table is further hampered by the existence of certain members of the staff who are present in the institute but not taking their class due to one or the other reason. I would suggest doing counseling to such teachers, or they may be warned that adverse entry in their C.R. can be made, if found guilty in future.

Overburdened with extra work

Many staff members have been given too much extra work other than teaching which consume most of their time. They hardly get any time to prepare the lesson for their forthcoming class. I would suggest that if routine type of work is given to the office staff then teachers would be able to take classes more efficiently and enthusiastically.-These are some of the methods which may be adopted for bringing good results in the Institute.

Yours faithfully,

X.Y.Z.

3.6 DRAFTING THE TECHNICAL REPORT

There was a time when engineers joked about not being great of English or spelling. But those days have gone. These days' technical people are in high demand. There are people who have very good technical skills and can write and communicate as well too. For example: our ex President Dr. A P J Abdul Kalam.

How will you increase your writing skill, if you feel a bit of it is lacking?

Build up your confidence - As an engineer, one has a logical mind and with technical writing, it becomes exactly what you need actually. You are a better writer than you think you are.

Don't over complicate things - you are not expected to produce a rocket. All you have to do is to put down in writing what you would otherwise say verbally. So think you are writing a set of explanatory notes to a friend. It becomes less difficult.

Tape it and then listen back to it- And transcribe it when you are listening the tape, you will come to know your weaknesses then again re-write it including those weaknesses. Then you will come to realize that you are really more than technocrat.

A word about editing – you have to do a bit of editing. Even good writers, need editing of their work. You just get better & better by practice.

Check Your Progress IV

Fill in the blanks:

- i) Engineer has a _____ mind.
- ii) Reports makes of _____ & _____ easier.
- iii) Mention two main points to increase the writing skill by a technocrat.
- iv) Reports clarify the relationship between _____ & _____.
- v) Reports are helpful in implementing the _____.

3.7 LET US SUM UP

A report is a summary of information. It is the organized statement of facts relating to a particular subject prepared by the PS/PA/Sec. after an independent inquiry presented to the interested person with or without recommendations. In an office, reports are prepared to see the progress of activities so that definite decisions can be taken by the management. An office reports is quite important as:

- 1) It provides the means of communication.
- 2) It provides the valuable records of business documents for future use.

- 3) Provides the results of investigations.
- 4) Provides the basis for the measurement of performance.

Reports may be ordinary reports & special reports.

Ordinary reports are also called routine reports. They contain the mere statement of facts in summarized form without any recommendations. But special reports are prepared by the individuals or body & presented to the superior with recommendations supported by the facts & arguments upon which the recommendations are based.

Report writing is an art. No formal rules can be laid down with regard to style & language to be adopted. Any style can be adopted so long as it serves the purpose for which the report is being written. However, general guidelines may be followed to produce a clear, concise & logical statement of information:

Report should be simple, clear & unambiguous. It should be non-technical. Negative Statement should be avoided. It should be written in first person. Narrative form of writing may be used. Conclusion & recommendations should be based on factual data. It should be written as briefly as possible to keep to the basic purpose.

Keeping in view of the above mentioned guidelines, the report writer will produce clear, concise, logical & forceful report. He has to proceed methodically i.e. he has to collect the material needed for the report. Data should be collected from all valuable sources. Data collected should be accurate & reliable. He has to classify, tabulate & analyze the data so that he may be able to give a concrete picture of the problem and then the report writer has to arrive at conclusion and formulate the recommendations. He will prepare the draft report & may seek the opinion of some experts before it is finally printed. The report is finally printed or typed after incorporating the suitable alterations & corrections. It is submitted to the proper authority after signing with date.

3.8 ANSWER TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

Check your Progress I

- a) Readable
- b) Emphasis
- c) Brevity
- d) Communication/source
- e) Successes
- f) Active
- g) Output
- h) Recommendations

Check Your Progress II

- a) Statutory
- b) Annual
- c) Technocrats
- d) Analytical
- e) Routine
- f) Informal

Check Your Progress III

- a) Title
- b) Comprehensive
- c) Definite
- d) Report
- e) First person

Check Your Progress IV

- i) logical
- ii) analysis, assessment
- iii) Transparency, Concise
- iv) input & output
- v) decisions

3.9 TERMINAL QUESTIONS

1. What is an office report? State the main points to be considered in drafting an office report.
2. What forms a good report? What are its different types?
3. Write short notes on
 - A) Formal & Informal report
 - B) Statutory & Non-Statutory report
4. Draft a report for submission to the principal of the Institute on the agitation of students for changing the subject teacher.
5. State some general principles which may help to produce a clear & accurate report.

- 6 Draft a report submission to the chairman of the company on a proposal for mechanization of the office.
- 7 Draft an Annual report to be read at the Annual function of the institute.
- 8 Why report writing is considered a useful activity?

3.10 SUGGESTED READINGS

Report Writing	by Graham Greaves & Hoftman
Administrative Office Management	by Johnson & Savage
Modern Office Management	by Littlefield & Peterson
Successful Technical Writing	by Tyler G. Hicks

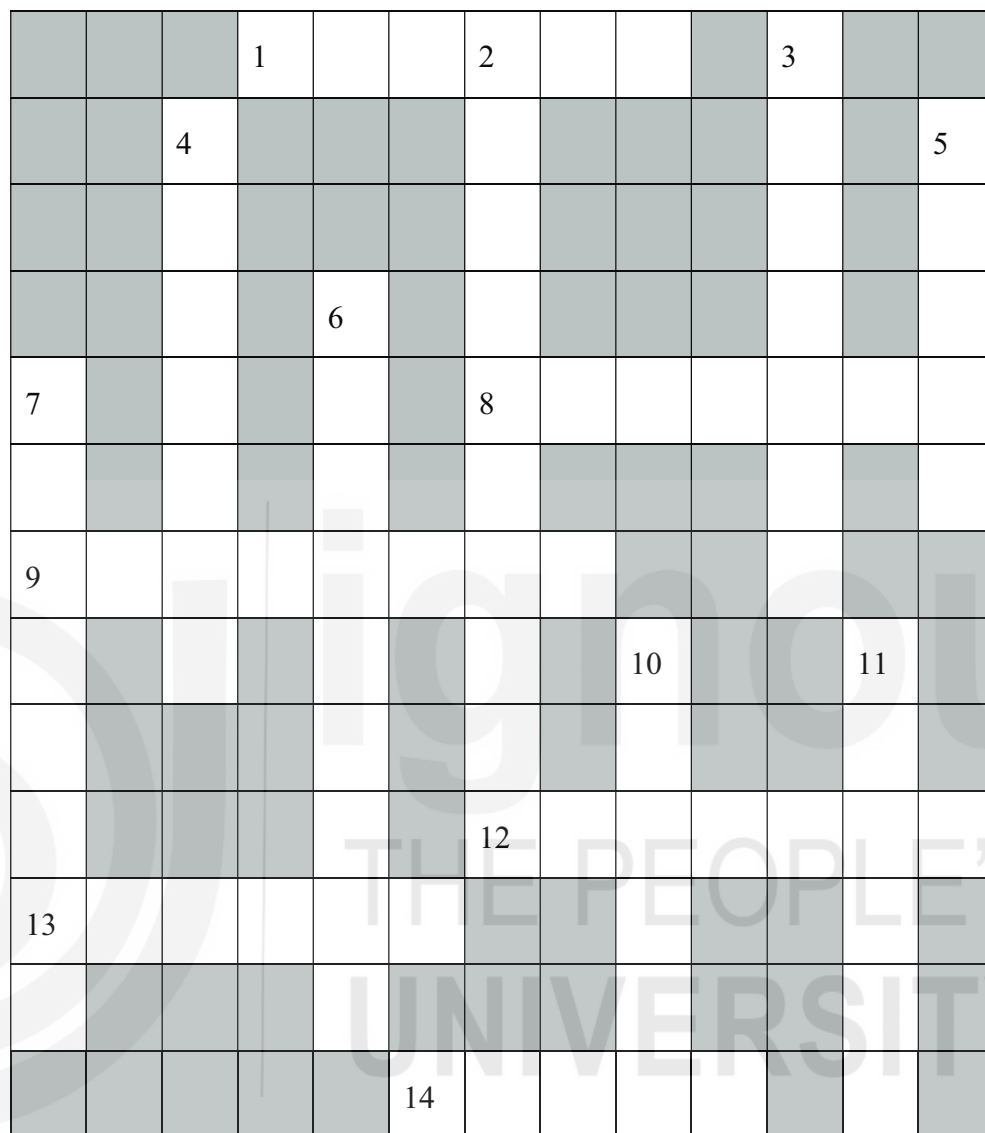
Text Books:

Office Management	by R.K. Chopra
Office Management	by P.K. Ghosh
Creative report writing	by L. Brown

3.11 ACTIVITIES

Crossword Puzzle

(Teachers may use such puzzles to make the lessons more interesting.)



Across: 1. Standardised type of report. (6)

8. Periodic report. (7)

9. Writing initial report. (8)

12. Record of decisions. (7)

13. Summary of information. (6)

14. Name. (5)

Down: 2. Internal letter. (10)

3. Indicates contents. (7)

4. Not a routine report. (7)

5. Concise. (5)

6. Report required by law. (9)

7. Prepare audit report. (8)

10. Statutory report. (6)

11. Summary. (6)

Answer to Crossword Puzzle (Solved)

			1 F	O	R	2 M	A	L		3 H		
		4 S				E				E		5 B
		P				M				A		R
		E		6 S		O				D		I
7 A		C		T		8 R	O	U	T	I	N	E
U		I		A		A				N		F
9 D	R	A	F	T	I	N	G			G		
I		L		U		D		10 A			11 P	
T				T		U		N			R	
O				O		12 M	I	N	U	T	E	S
13 R	E	P	O	R	T			U			C	
S				Y				A			I	
					14 T	I	T	L	E		S	

